

The Greatest Happiness Principle: Mill's Case for Utilitarianism

An original lesson plan inspired by **John Stuart Mill's Utilitarianism** (Project Gutenberg). Not affiliated with or endorsed by Project Gutenberg or John Stuart Mill. Explore the original course: <https://www.gutenberg.org/ebooks/11224>

GRADE LEVEL	DURATION	TOPICS
Grades 11-12 / Intro College	65 minutes	Ethics

“Mill claims that pleasure and freedom from pain are the only things desirable as ends — is he right, and does his distinction between 'higher' and 'lower' pleasures rescue utilitarianism from the charge that it's a doctrine fit only for swine?”

Learning Objectives

By the end of this lesson, students will be able to:

- Explain Mill's Greatest Happiness Principle and how it defines right action in terms of the net balance of pleasure over pain for all affected.
- Analyze Mill's distinction between higher (intellectual/moral) and lower (bodily) pleasures and his 'competent judges' test for ranking them.
- Evaluate Mill's defense of utilitarianism against a major objection, such as the swine objection or the demandingness of impartial calculation.

Materials Needed

- Whiteboard
- Excerpt handout: selected passages from Mill's Utilitarianism, Chapter 2 (the 'swine' passage and higher/lower pleasures)
- Case-study cards describing a hypothetical 'experience machine' that guarantees pleasurable sensations disconnected from reality
- Graphic organizer contrasting Bentham's purely quantitative calculus with Mill's qualitative distinction

Lesson Procedure

Hook: Would You Plug In?

8 min

Describe a machine that would give a person maximum pleasurable sensations forever, disconnected from real achievement or relationships. Ask students to vote on whether they would plug in permanently; most decline. Note that this is a genuine puzzle for any ethical theory that treats pleasure as the only thing of value.

Direct Instruction: The Greatest Happiness Principle

18 min

Present Mill's core claim that actions are right in proportion as they tend to promote happiness, understood as pleasure and the absence of pain. Contrast this with Bentham's purely quantitative hedonic calculus, then present Mill's key move: pleasures differ in quality as well as quantity, and 'competent judges' who have experienced both a higher and a lower pleasure reliably prefer the higher one, even at some cost to the total quantity of pleasure.

Close Reading in Pairs

15 min

In pairs, students read the assigned excerpt containing Mill's famous 'swine' passage and his line about a dissatisfied Socrates being preferable to a satisfied fool. They identify, in their own words, Mill's argument for why humans would not accept a lower, more brutish existence even if it contained more total pleasure.

Whole-Class Discussion

18 min

Connect back to the experience-machine hook. Debate whether Mill's higher/lower distinction is a principled extension of a pleasure-based ethics, or whether it secretly imports independent, non-hedonistic judgments about what's noble or worthwhile — which would mean utilitarianism is no longer purely about pleasure at all.

Closure

6 min

Ask students to state, in one sentence, whether Mill's response to the swine objection succeeds, and briefly poll the class's overall verdict.

Discussion Questions

- 1 Does Mill's 'competent judges' test for ranking pleasures secretly abandon a purely quantitative, pleasure-based standard of value, since it seems to smuggle in independent judgments about what's noble or worthwhile?
- 2 Would you decline to plug into the pleasure machine, and if so, what does that reveal about whether pleasure is really the only thing we value?
- 3 Mill argues that anyone who has experienced both a higher and a lower pleasure prefers the higher — is this claim actually true of people you know, or of yourself?
- 4 Does the Greatest Happiness Principle require impartially weighing a stranger's happiness equally with your own family's? Is that a strength or a weakness of the theory?
- 5 Mill claims his utilitarianism is compatible with individual rights and justice — do you find this compatible, or is there a deeper tension between maximizing overall happiness and respecting individual rights?

Assessment

Students write a short analysis (400–500 words) responding to the 'swine' objection to utilitarianism in their own words, explaining how Mill's higher/lower pleasures distinction attempts to answer it, and offering their own assessment of whether the response succeeds or merely relocates the problem.

Extension Activity

Have students track their own activities and rough 'pleasure' for a single day, then classify each pleasure as higher or lower by Mill's standard, and write a short reflection on whether Mill's ranking matches their own intuitive sense of which activities were most worthwhile.

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